

tion with Google's decision to bake Flash support into its Android devices, Flash doesn't appear to be going anywhere anytime soon.

In the past for web and application developers, limiting factors to be considered with the efficiency of software was the computer's processor speed and more recently the Internet bandwidth. This meant the user has to spend 10 minutes entering data and then wait two hours for calculations to run, or 10 seconds typing a URL and wait 30 seconds for the web page to load. This led to the developers putting in most of their effort into making the processing or transfer faster and not much effort went into the efficiency of data entry fields and user engagement. Nowadays the exact opposite is true, we spend more time entering letters and numbers than we do waiting for pages to load or calculations to run. User engagement has become increasingly relevant. Radical new user interfaces are being developed for the modern day RIAs and even faster advancements are expected in the future changing how one will be interacting with digital devices.

Learning RIA technologies has never been easier. With companies trying to promote the use of their own technologies, there are innumerable resources available online either by Adobe, Microsoft or other open source communities. With the right creative and technical knowledge and prowess getting yourself hired in this area could be very easy and exciting. Through the rest of this Fast Track we will be focusing at building RIAs for the desktop as well as for mobile platforms with the Flex 4.5 SDK and using tools like Flash Builder 4.5.

Is HTML5 the future?

HTML5 is hailed as the future of the web and RIA development. But it could take a very long time for it to be mature enough for extensive use. HTML5 is large and complex, and if we are to trust the current projections by the people working on this particular spec like Ian Hickson of Google and David Hyatt of Apple, for all parts to be finished it would be the year 2022, some 18 years after the process started in 2004.

However, some Web sites are already using if not the complete spec but a subset of HTML5. For example, YouTube and Vimeo have already rolled out use of the video element in HTML5. The working subset of HTML5 is nowhere near the power of Flash. There are many advanced effects that are only available in Flash or Silverlight or Java. For example, Google, which is driving HTML5, relies on Flash in Google Maps for the Streetview and in Gmail for the multiple file upload capability. There are tens of thousands of